

LAUNCH PAD · A GUIDE'S LESSON PLAN BOOK

The Helm Year

What do I do when there is no easy answer?

A guide's book for Year Three of the Launch Pad, written so a learner can read every page.

VIBRANT LIFE

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A short opening note

This is a book for the guide who runs the third and final year of the Launch Pad - the year called The Helm. It is also a book you, the learner, are welcome to read cover to cover. There is nothing in here to hide from you.

That is a promise with a shape. Everything in this book is safe and honest for a learner to read; nothing in it manages or manipulates anyone. Lines in “quotes” are things a guide might say aloud. Everything else is written for the guide to understand and hold - the reasons behind the moves, the care under the plan. When a note is written for the guide, it is still written to be read by you. There is no second, secret version.

One more thing to say plainly at the start: this is the heaviest year in the three-year story, and the safety floor is fullest here. The material is real. It touches hard calls, mortality, shame, leadership, and, at the end, leaving. Because it is heavy, the care around it is built up thick. The intensity is opt-in by readiness - always. It is never forced on anyone. A learner meets the hard material when they are ready and steady, and the lighter path is always honorable, never a lesser version of the year. Held well, this year changes people for good. That is the whole point of building the container so carefully.

Part 1 - For everyone: what this year is

The year's question

The Helm is the year of **the hard call - and loving the life around it**.

The whole question of the year is this: *What do I do when there is no easy answer?* Not “how do I win,” but “how do I face something that cannot be cleanly won, make the call from my own principles, name what it costs, and not lose myself doing it - while still loving my actual life?”

The journey

The Launch Pad is three years, three expeditions. The first year, Origin, was about **dreaming it** - who am I? The second year, The Forge, was about **building it** - what is worth solving? The Helm is the resolution. It is where you learn to make a real decision from your own principles, in the open, in front of your people, and still go home and love your life.

The arc runs self, then world, then the hard call. By now you know your story and you have found work worth doing. This year you learn to reason under genuine uncertainty, to live with a hard decision, to lead your peers, to be mentored by adults who walk the road ahead of you - and to choose life *because* you have looked at hard things, not by looking away from them.

The name for the daily practice of this year is the **no-win scenario** - sometimes called the Kobayashi Maru. It is the practice of standing inside a dilemma that has no clean answer, long enough to reason from principle instead of reaching for the exit. It is the same muscle you have been building the whole time. In Origin you made small real choices in games. In The Forge you stood inside questions too big to close. This year you make the hard call inside a situation that cannot be won. Same muscle, one more turn.

What you make and carry

Three things belong to you this year, and one of them you carry out the door for the rest of your life.

- **The Captain's Log.** This has been yours since your first day, across all three years. It is your private voice - your record of what you met and what you carried. A guide never reads it to grade you or check on you; it was never surveillance and it never will be. At the end of the cycle it is handed to you fully, with no copy kept behind.
- **The Mantle.** This year you take up a Mantle - a role, a way of standing, an "I am someone who can hold a hard call." You take it up in the first session, you wear it into the leadership work and the Council, and at the very end you decide, on your own, whether to keep it or leave it. Both choices are true. The choosing is the point.
- **The Vineyard.** This is the thing you love that has nothing to do with the curriculum - the instrument, the trail, the craft, the friendship, the game. It was planted way back in Origin as the quiet twin of the Captain's Log, and by now it has roots. It is never made useful. No one grades it, no one turns it into a lesson. This year it ripens, and at the end it becomes the small gift you leave for the room. Loving your life is not a footnote to making hard calls. It is what the hard calls are *for*.

The promises

Everything in the Launch Pad sits inside six refusals - things this program will never do to you:

1. No grades or completion rates visible to anyone but you.
2. No ranking, no leaderboards, no comparing your progress to anyone else's.
3. No handing you pre-packaged answers to memorize - you make the meaning; the guide does not author it for you.
4. No imposed deadlines - you set your own pace, and "I didn't get to it" is honored, not punished.
5. No treating your worth as your output - a quest you set down with something learned counts as fully as one you finished.
6. No surveillance - your data is yours, not the school's.

And one more, over all of them: **you may refuse the structure itself.** A learner who declines a quest is fully honored, not marked as a failure.

How we work

The week. Two days you run yourself and two days you work with the guide, plus a protected fallow day. On a guide day you arrive at your own pace and work on your own things for the first hour, then the whole group gathers for a settle and a “how are you, really?” circle, then the day’s real work, a shared meal, hands-on time, and a glad close. On a self-guided day you run your own hours - reading, core academics, your project, your writing - and the guide checks in around midday. The fallow day is protected: rest, play, friendship, making for no reason. It is never earned and never filled.

The Log, captured however you hold it. You capture your days in the Captain’s Log in whatever way is yours - written, drawn, spoken, listed. There is no one correct format. It is yours.

The Vineyard. The thing you love runs alongside the whole year, usually on the fallow day or the tail of the lighter guided day. No prompt, no harvest, no purpose announced.

How “no” works here. You can decline any quest. When you do, you name why - not to pass a test, but because naming your reasoning is itself part of the work. The guide can ask you a Socratic question about it (“when do you think you’ll first run into this for real?”), but the guide has a voice, never a veto. Your reasoned no stands. And when you say no, the guide holds it a specific way - the **Curious No**: first they receive the no whole (“Okay. You’re not doing this one.”), then they offer the door once without pushing (“if you ever want to tell me what’s behind that, I’d like to know - no rush”), then they keep you inside the room (“come sit with me, you don’t have to do the thing”). Curiosity is never a lever to change your mind.

The settle. Every guide day opens with the same body-first settle: three slow breaths, the out-breath longer than the in-breath (about a 4-count in, a 6-count out), feet flat, one hand where you feel your breath. On heavy days there are also short resets in the middle of the work - stand, shake out, a short walk - and a real come-down at the end. This is not a mood. It is a fixed, learnable move, said the same way every time, so that by now your body knows it. It is yours to keep for life. When you are forty and something cracks you open, this is a way to come home to yourself.

The closing minute. After anything that opens you up, you take a quiet minute - alone, in your head or in your Log - and cross back through three fixed lines. They are always the same three, in the same order:

- *What did I meet?*
- *What do I carry back?*

- *What's different in me now - even a little?*

And “I don’t know yet” is a real answer that closes the practice just as honestly as any other. There is no artifact, ever - nothing to fill in, nothing handed up. It is spoken or thought, never recorded, never read. It is a skill you keep. The whole point is that you can run it on yourself for the rest of your life, with no guide in the room.

The one adult outside the room. There is always at least one adult you can talk to who is not the guide, if you need it. If something comes up that is bigger than a hard conversation - a grief that will not settle, a danger, someone hurting you - the guide’s job is not to fix it themselves but to help you reach real help, fast, without shame. That is not the guide breaking trust. That is what care actually looks like, and it is named out loud on the first day so it is never a surprise.

Part 2 - For the guide: teaching this year

The shape of the year, and naming the destination on day one

The Helm runs about thirty weeks across seven sessions - four short (roughly three weeks each) and three long (about six weeks each). The last session is the harvest, and for the founding cohort it flows into the Launch.

On the very first day, name the destination out loud. This is the single most important framing move of the year:

SAY

“In thirty weeks you will stand before your people and make a hard call in the open - the Council - and some of you will then walk out the door into your own lives - the Launch. Everything between now and then is how you get ready to be worthy of that chair.”

Once the mountain is named on day one, every session becomes a rung toward it. The reasoning work is how the captain thinks. The empathy work is how the captain feels the cost. The mentorship work is learning the terrain from those who walked it. The leadership work is how the captain holds the room. Give them the mountain first, and the whole year points somewhere.

Three threads run through the whole year and give it a spine:

1. **The destination**, named day one (the Council, and the Launch).
2. **The Mantle**, one physical object taken up in Session 1 and carried to the end.
3. **The Vineyard**, the un-useful joy, tended for years, ripening now.

The season's daily frame: the no-win call

The daily ritual of The Helm is the no-win scenario - the Kobayashi Maru idea. Name it plainly as the same muscle the learners have built all along: small choices in Origin, standing inside big questions in The Forge, and now the hard call inside a situation that cannot be cleanly won.

The famous move in the old story - reprogram the test, beat the unbeatable - is the bait, not the lesson. For near-adults months from the real world, the deeper truth is this: the test is not whether you can always find the clever third option. It is who you are when there is no third option. Sometimes the freighter dies. So teach both halves. Half the wisdom is finding the third door when it is really there. The other half is knowing when there isn't one, choosing anyway from principle, naming the cost, and not losing yourself carrying it. The highest thing this whole three-year arc can produce is not "the learner found the clever way out." It is: the learner faced something that could not be won, made the hard call from principle, named what it cost, and did not lose themselves doing it.

The safety floor, fullest here

This year has the heaviest material in the whole program, so the floor is built up thickest. Do not treat the floor as the brake on honesty. It is the suspension that lets the vehicle take rough ground at speed. Honest-and-held changes a person; honest-and-abandoned wounds them. The whole difference is that one word: held.

The floor has these parts, and they are non-negotiable:

- **The settle, the reset, the come-down.** Every heavy day opens with the settle (regulate the room before you activate it), has short physical resets in the middle of the work, and ends with a real come-down that lands people back in the present. A tired guide cuts these first because they feel like overhead. They are not overhead. They are the floor.
- **Stepping out and back.** There is a named place a learner can go to, set up in week one, and they never have to ask. Coming back in costs nothing - they slip back during a soft moment, no scene, no acknowledgment demanded.
- **A crew that holds each other.** On heavy days every learner is paired with one other learner who simply notices them. Frame it as a crew, always - never "assigned to watch you flood." A hero surrounded by a crew is still the hero; a patient surrounded by a ward is a patient. Keep them the hero.
- **A second adult present for the heaviest sessions.** Three sessions carry material heavy enough that one adult cannot both hold the room's deliberation and catch the one learner

quietly going under. On the deep day of those three, a second adult is required in the room - not for childcare, but as a second pair of eyes whose only job is to leave with the learner who needs to leave, so you never have to choose between the room and the wound. The three are Session 2 (the heaviest dilemmas), Session 4 (the death scene in *Our Town*), and Session 7 (the public Council). The second adult can be a trained peer, a co-op parent who has done the safety briefing, or another adult freed for that hour. Name it as a precondition, not a hope. If a second adult genuinely cannot be secured for a given heavy week, the deep block for that week lightens or defers - the lighter version runs, and the deep version waits until the room can be held. That is the floor working, not the guide failing.

- **The referral pathway, in plain terms.** You are a life-coach and mentor, not a licensed clinician. This year surfaces real clinical material - grief around mortality, shame, hard days - more and earlier than any prior year. Your job is not to treat it. It is to recognize when something is past coaching, hold the moment safely, and route it to real help fast. Route now (do not “work it in a session”) for any mention of suicide, self-harm, or wanting to not be here; any disclosure of abuse or someone hurting a learner; acute crisis; disordered-eating signals; substance crisis; or threats to others. When in doubt, route. Stay with the learner, never leave them alone in crisis, move to the designated quiet space, be calm and present, do not probe or counsel. The referral roster must be built real - real names and current numbers - before Session 1 runs, and the one line that must never stay blank is a named, warm-referral therapist arranged in advance. In Idaho everyone is a mandatory reporter, and 988 is the crisis line; keep those numbers current and on paper. Name the one limit to confidentiality on day one, woven into the year’s opening agreement, so it is a promise kept rather than a surprise.
- **Keep confidences safe.** Almost everything a learner says and writes here is theirs and private. The one thing you cannot keep private is danger - if a learner is in danger or someone is hurting them, your job is to help them get real help. Say this plainly, up front, once.
- **Material is chosen, not sprung; opt-in by readiness.** The heaviest content is previewed, alternates are ready, and no learner is required to disclose anything about their own life to take part. The lighter version of the whole year is the honorable default first pass - full intensity is opt-in for a later, more-ready cohort, never opt-out by exhaustion.

Leadership styles taught by example

In the leadership work you will use well-known ship captains and public leaders as archetypes - different styles of leading, all real. Present them plainly, as public teaching examples. “Here are four real captains with four different styles; which do you lead like?” is a teaching device, nothing more. They are not insider lore and they are not personas giving advice. They are examples a learner can look up on their own, the way you would study any public leader.

Holding a “no” - the Curious No, three beats

When a learner declines, run one move you can hold even under load:

1. **Receive the no, whole.** “Okay. You’re not doing this one.” Honor it *before* any curiosity, so curiosity is never felt as a lever.
2. **Offer the door once, don’t push it.** “If you ever want to tell me what’s behind that, I’d genuinely like to know - no rush, nothing owed.”
3. **Keep them inside the encounter.** “Come sit with me, you don’t have to do the thing.”

Your Socratic question stays a mirror, never fear-leverage. Ask “when do you think you’ll first run into this for real?” - not “what happens the first time you need this and no one is beside you?” And “the right kind of scared” is the learner’s to name about themselves. It is never yours to assign to them.

Watch-fors, and protect yourself

This year asks the most of the guide, too. Holding hard material costs the holder, and the whole floor depends on you having enough reserve left to notice the one learner going under.

- **Run your own floor.** Do your own settle, your own reset at day’s end, your own closing minute. This is safety instrumentation, not self-care - a dysregulated guide cannot run the watch-and-pivot. The room reads your nervous system faster than any lesson plan can counter.
- **Debrief after every heavy day.** After each of the three heaviest deep days, debrief with your witness-person before the next heavy session. Do not carry it alone.
- **A second adult on the heaviest days** protects you as much as the room.
- **Lightening or deferring is honorable.** If the load is too much in a given week, the lighter version is the floor working. Capacity comes first, then enrollment, then revenue - never the reverse.

Part 3 - The sessions

Each session below gives you: what it's for, a plain word for the learner, the flow, things you might say, the settle and closing minute, watch-fors, and what you'll need.

1

The Mantle

WEEKS 1-3, SHORT

What it's for. To open the year by meeting imposter feeling honestly - naming it as the felt sensation of growth, not a defect - and to take up the Mantle you will carry all year. The imposter's lie is "everyone else belongs here and I snuck in." The truth is that accomplished people feel it too, and it fades not by proving yourself but by acting anyway.

For the learner. "Who are you to make hard calls? Why you?" That knot in your stomach when you reach past what you can already do - that is not proof you don't belong. It is the feeling of growing into the person you are becoming. You do not wait to feel ready. You take up the mantle, and the sense of being worthy follows the acting.

The flow. - Week 1 opens the year: name the destination (the Council and the Launch), introduce the no-win frame as the same muscle from Origin and The Forge, re-open the Vineyard ("the part of the week that is yours to love"), and name imposter feeling as universal and as a growth signal. On the deep day, you and an invited mentor model imposter feeling - genuinely and specifically ("here is a time I felt like a fraud"). The learners *receive* it. That alone teaches "accomplished people feel this too." - Week 2 turns "who am I to do this?" into "why not you?" and builds the Evidence File - real proof of competence, pulled forward from the Year-1 portfolio, the whole cycle paying off. Each learner also chooses a real act, this week, that scares them a little - take a real chair, make a real call, ship a real thing - and discovers the worthiness on the far side. - Week 3 is the Mantle rite, in four movements. **Threshold:** each learner names aloud, in their own words, what they are taking up ("I am someone who can hold a hard call") - claimed, not conferred. Speaking it while not yet fully believing it *is* the rite. **Return-object:** they put on the mantle and find the Evidence File as its lining - proof, in the pocket, that they have already done hard things. **Witness:** a named witness reflects the crossing back ("I saw you take that up"). **Reincorporation:** the mantle is not taken off at day's end. It becomes the year's through-line, worn toward the Council and the Launch.

This is the rebuilt session - read this carefully. The old version had "everyone shares a time they felt like a fraud, going around the circle." That is gone, on purpose. Shame and imposter feeling are not the same emotion. Imposter feeling ("I don't belong here yet") is generative. Public shame disclosure in a peer group, at the age of peak peer-sensitivity, can wound lastingly

- and opting out of a shame ritual in front of peers becomes its own quiet shame event. So the structure is fixed:

- The dissolving power comes from **adults modeling, learners receiving** - not from any learner being required to share.
- No circle-round, no going-around.
- If a learner *wants* to share, it is **non-attributed** - written on a card, read aloud by the guide with no author named (“someone here once felt...”).
- **Abstention is invisible.** In a “receive, then optionally write a card” structure, no one can see who chose not to write. That is the only way opt-out is real in a peer room.
- The Evidence File comes immediately after, same session. Never leave a room having surfaced shame without building the counterweight of real evidence of competence.

Things to say. - “In thirty weeks you make a hard call in the open, before your people. Everything from here gets you ready to be worthy of that chair.” - “That feeling of not-belonging-yet? Accomplished people feel it too. It doesn’t mean you snuck in. It means you’re reaching.” - “Why not you? If not you, who?” - “You don’t wait to feel worthy and then act. You act, and worthiness follows.” - (At the rite) “I saw you take that up.”

The settle and the closing minute. Open with the settle - shame lives in the body (heat, dropped gaze, a curled spine), so regulate the room before you touch the material. Keep exposure titrated: receive first, low-stakes. Close with a return. This is an opening session, so the closing minute matters: *What did I meet? What do I carry back? What’s different in me now - even a little?* “I don’t know yet” is a real close.

Watch-fors. A learner who dips into shame needs the room to treat it as normal and needs the exit ramp they can use without asking. A genuine shame disclosure can shade toward something that needs real help - the referral pathway is live before this session runs. Guard the order so that any modeling is never the price of admission to the Mantle; the evidence of worth must be reachable by the learner who cannot speak.

What you’ll need. An invited mentor for the modeling; cards for optional non-attributed sharing; each learner’s Year-1 portfolio for the Evidence File; the physical mantle object and a named witness for the rite; the exit ramp and quiet space set up; the referral pathway live.

Session 2 - No Easy Answers (weeks 4-9, long) - one of the three heaviest

What it's for. To learn to reason through real moral dilemmas from principle, out loud, without an answer key. The world does not hand you the right answer. The win is not the verdict - it is the quality of the reasoning and the honesty about the cost. This is how the captain who will hold the Council learns to think.

For the learner. Some questions do not have a clean right answer, and pretending they do is a lie. This session teaches you to stand inside a hard question long enough to reason from your principles instead of grabbing for the exit. You will study real cases through story, so you can think about heavy things at full weight without anyone having to confess anything about their own life.

The flow. The method is moral dilemmas told through allegory (well-known dramatic episodes) tied to real historical cases - personhood (paired with the Dred Scott case), due process under fear (paired with McCarthyism), loyalty versus truth (paired with whistleblowing). Weeks 4 through 6 build the reasoning craft through progressively harder cases. Weeks 7 and 8 are the heaviest cases, previewed and alternated, with a second adult present. Week 9 is the harvest: each learner writes a reasoned position on a hard case, held from principle - not "won."

The spine of the session is the **Reasoning Standard** - five structural questions the reasoning must answer, none of which is "what is the right answer." Use it to coach, to self-assess, and to hold yourself to as well:

1. **Principles named** - which two or more genuine goods conflict here? (If there is only one real principle, it is not a dilemma - it may be a rationalized wrong. Say which.)
2. **Cost owned** - what does your path cost, and to whom? (A path that claims to be free is hiding its cost.)
3. **Steelman survived** - can you state the position you rejected well enough that its holder would say "yes, that's it"?
4. **Reversibility** - would you accept this reasoning if you were the person it costs?
5. **Framework visible** - are you reasoning through consequences, duty, character, or care? What does a different lens see that yours misses?

Two guardrails to teach: the stages of moral reasoning (Kohlberg's map) describe *arguments*, never rank *people* - name that the map has its own contested limits. And teach the distinction between a genuine dilemma and a rationalized wrong. Some paired cases are real dilemmas.

Some are not - Dred Scott is the study of how a system reasoned itself into evil, not “the other side of a hard call.” A curriculum that cannot tell those apart teaches false equivalence. Teaching learners to tell them apart teaches the sharpest blade of the year. Real cases get real study - primary voices, the human cost named - or the pairing drops to allegory only. Honor the reality, or do not borrow its weight.

Things to say. - “The world doesn’t come with an answer key. The win here isn’t the answer - it’s how well you reasoned and how honestly you named the cost.” - “Allegory isn’t the watered-down version. It’s the technology that lets us think about the hardest things at full weight while your own unhealed places stay safely behind the glass.” - “Say the strongest version of the side you disagree with - well enough that someone who holds it would say, yes, that’s exactly it.” - “Dred Scott isn’t the other side of a dilemma. It’s how a whole system reasoned itself into evil. Learning to tell those apart is the whole game.” - (In the heaviest weeks) “Today’s story touches death and the choice to end suffering. You can step out any time, you don’t owe anyone a reason, and there’s water and a chair by the window.”

The settle and the closing minute. Every heavy day: open settle, short resets between activations (a 30-second orienting, not only at the end), close return. Pre-brief before every flagged-heavy episode - name the terrain, name the exit, name that no reason is owed. This is arrival, not ambush, and it is the highest-leverage, lowest-cost thing you do. The dilemma work is an opening; close it with the closing minute (the affective twin of the Reasoning Standard - reason the hard call, *and* re-cross what it stirred).

Watch-fors. Second adult required on the heaviest deep days. Preview-and-alternate the heaviest episodes - assisted death, coercion, identity and conformity - with alternates chosen before the day, never improvised. The dilemma can be unflinching about the world; the learner’s own interior is never required as material. If the reassurance signal starts to over-announce (“we expect you to break”), thin the *signal* - frame the crew as trust, not vigilance - but never thin the floor’s actual availability.

What you’ll need. The allegory episodes and their alternates pre-selected; the paired real cases with primary sources; the Reasoning Standard on one page; a second adult secured for the heavy weeks; the somatic floor and exit ramp in place; the referral pathway live.

3

The Ripple

WEEKS 10-12, SHORT

What it's for. To learn consequence-thinking - looking one, two, three moves downstream of a choice, and being honest that you cannot see all the way. Good captains think in ripples, not single points. This is a deliberately lighter, playful beat between the two heaviest sessions.

For the learner. A hard call doesn't end when you make it. It sets things in motion - some you meant, some you didn't. This session is about looking downstream before you act, and staying humble about the part of the river you can't see yet.

The flow. The tools are games and maps: the Ripple Board (map the first-, second-, and third-order effects of a choice), the Monkey's Paw (every wish granted with an unforeseen cost - the shadow side of "solutions"), counterfactual history (change one thing, follow the ripples), and the Pre-Mortem (imagine the choice already failed - why?). Week 10 opens with the games, week 11 goes downstream two and three moves, week 12 harvests a real decision traced forward, with blind spots owned and agency kept.

Because this session is medium-weight and safe, it is one of the good homes for meeting a hard thing with only the ordinary supports rather than the full scaffold - the guide present, the exit available, but the visible net turned down. This is chosen and named, never sprung, and only for the ready launch-year learner. Reduce the visible scaffold, never the floor's availability.

Things to say. - "Every choice sends ripples. Chase the cascade - then what? And then what?" - "The wish always comes with a twist. What's the shadow of this solution?" - "You can't see all the way downstream, and pretending you can is its own mistake. The move is: act wisely, watch for the ripples, adjust."

The settle and the closing minute. Carry the open settle and the glad close even though the day is light - a light session still bookends. Closing minute as usual.

Watch-fors. Consequence-thinking can tip into anxiety ("what if everything goes wrong"). Always pair it with agency - "and here is the move you can still make." The point is wiser action, not fear of acting. Keep this session light on purpose; do not import heavy material into the room's breath between the two hardest sessions. No second adult needed.

What you'll need. The Ripple Board setup; a Monkey's Paw story or two; counterfactual prompts; each learner's own Forge project for the Pre-Mortem.

Session 4 - The Stage (weeks 13-18, long) - one of the three heaviest

What it's for. To feel a hard call from inside the lives it touches, through theatre - and to practice the discipline of stepping fully into another life and cleanly back out again. The distance of the stage is a safety feature, like allegory: you can *be* the person who makes the other choice.

For the learner. To make a hard call well, you have to feel from inside the lives it touches. Theatre is the safest way to practice standing in someone else's shoes - and stepping back out whole is as important as stepping in.

The flow. Warm-ups and improv open it (week 13). Monologue work follows - each learner finds or writes a monologue from someone facing a hard call and speaks that truth from the inside; performing is voluntary, observing is equal (week 14). Then the keystone text, *Our Town*, and its question: "Do any human beings ever realize life while they live it?" Emily returns from death to relive one ordinary day (week 15, the death-scene deep day). Then Forum Theatre (weeks 16-17): act out a hard-call scene, then let the room stop it and try a different choice - deliberation made physical, which pays off directly in the Council. Week 18 harvests a performed moment of empathy - stepping fully into another life and back out whole.

Archetypes are taught as **doorways, not identities**: you try a way of being on; you are not it. "I encountered the Hero," never "I am the Hero."

Two closes are kept strictly separate here. **De-roling** closes a *role* - "that wasn't me." The **closing minute** closes a real *feeling* the role opened - "that was me, and I carry it, and I'm still here." Never de-role real grief. De-roling teaches "that wasn't me"; grief needs "that was me, and I am still here." Keep the line bright.

Things to say. - "You're not becoming this person. You're trying them on. It's a doorway, not who you are." - "Do any of us ever really realize life while we're living it? Every, every minute?" - (After an embodiment, the de-roling) "Say your own name. Name three things true about your real life right now - I am [name], I am 17, it's Tuesday, I have soccer after this. Now shake out your hands and feel the floor." - (For real grief that surfaces) "That was real. That was you. Let's not push it out - it can stay, and you're still here."

The settle and the closing minute. Open settle, mid-work discharge, close return, every heavy day. De-role after *every* embodiment, with the real mechanic (say your name, three true things about your real life, remove the prop, shake out, feel the floor) - not once per session, every

single time a body wears another life. The nervous system does not know a role is pretend; it runs the state for real. Then the closing minute for anything real the role opened.

Watch-fors. Second adult required on the *Our Town* death-scene deep day - it is the one place the season's allegory shield does not apply, because death on the stage *is* the real thing, and a grieving learner takes a direct hit. Know which learners are grieving before that scene runs - a recent loss makes Emily's return a direct hit, not allegory. This is a judgment made before the day, never improvised, with a previewed exit named for that scene specifically. Roles are always chosen; a role can be given to the tribe only, observed rather than performed, or declined. Protect the theatre-as-play as genuine joy, not only a safety warm-up, and keep the Vineyard distinct from the de-roling toolkit.

What you'll need. Monologue sources; the *Our Town* text and material; a second adult for the death scene; the pre-loaded knowledge of who is grieving; a previewed exit; the de-roling space and mechanic; the somatic floor and exit ramp; the referral pathway live.

Session 5 - The Arena of Voices (weeks 19-21, short)

What it's for. To learn from real adults walking the road ahead - professional mentors and guest speakers - and to learn the real skill of being mentored well. No one navigates alone. Being mentored is a threshold: being seen by someone you admire.

For the learner. The people further down your road are a gift. Being mentored well is a skill: come prepared, ask a question worth a busy person's time, follow up. A good question is itself the gift you give back.

The flow. Week 19 teaches the art of being mentored (prepare, ask, follow up) and drafts real interview questions. Week 20 the voices arrive - a Boise guest speaker who has made real hard calls, and each learner's own informational interview. Week 21 harvests a real conversation and the honest account of what it opened, and closes the loop with genuine thanks.

The two-track design (binding). A guest speaker is a window; a one-to-one mentor is a door. Secure them differently.

- **Guest speakers (the window): buildable now, with a modest policy.** Guide present for the entire visit (this alone satisfies the never-alone rule); a public, observable setting; a short expectations sheet the speaker acknowledges (topic scope, no private contact with learners, no photos without consent); parent notification of who and when. No background check is

required for a one-time supervised group speaker - the supervision *is* the control, and requiring checks would kill the ability to bring interesting people in. Watch the conversion point: a speaker who starts contacting a learner afterward has walked through the door without being vetted for it - route any follow-up through the guide, which moves them to the mentor track.

- **One-to-one professional mentors (the door): not cleared until the container exists.**

Observable channel only - no private messages, personal social media, or off-platform contact; the guide sees that contact exists and how often, never reads the content for assessment. Never-alone satisfied by structure - default remote and monitored; in person only with the guide present or in a public setting, never a private residence or vehicle. A background check before first contact. Three-party informed consent (parent, learner, mentor) plus signed boundaries. A no-fault off-ramp - a learner ends or reports a match with one word to the guide, no reason owed, no confrontation. A written safeguarding and mandatory-reporting policy authored once, on paper, before the first match. And a counsel review of Idaho duty-of-care, mandatory reporting, and liability. Build the container before the first match.

- **Reciprocity - honor the givers, never mine them.** Pay real honoraria and cover costs (a waived fee is accepted only if freely offered, never solicited). Offer a menu of depths - one informational interview, a short arc, or a sustained mentorship - with the one-off honored identically to the year-long. Bounded terms and a dignified exit. The teen arrives prepared. Close the loop: thank them, tell them what their gift did, ask whether it served them too. A professional's hard-call story is a gift, never the price of admission - especially a trauma-proximate one, which is invited freely and never required as content. The mentor is not the load-bearing safeguarding adult; route weight it wasn't built for to the guide.

Source mentors warmly, through communities that already hold relationship - the parent network, local professional and civic bodies - never cold extraction.

Things to say. - "A good question is a gift to the person answering it. Come with one worth their time." - (The mentor-rejection preload, before any outreach) "If you reach out and hear nothing back - that is not a verdict on you. Busy people are busy. The non-response says nothing about your worth." - "Tell them what their answer did for you. Close the loop."

The settle and the closing minute. Carry the settle and glad close. Closing minute for what a real conversation opened - or did not.

Watch-fors. The mentor-rejection preload matters: reaching out to an admired professional and being ignored is a real wound at this age. Teach "the non-response is not a verdict" *before* the

outreach, not as consolation after. This preload is also a fitting place for a ready learner to meet an ordinary-stakes hard thing with ordinary support - never a manufactured wound, always gated to the ready learner, never for one already over-hardened. Keep the mentor boundary bright.

What you'll need. The guest-speaker expectations sheet and parent notifications; the mentor-track container fully built before any one-to-one match; a reciprocity plan and honoraria budget; thank-you materials; the settle in place.

6

The Bridge

WEEKS 22-24, SHORT

What it's for. To practice leading peers and being led well. Leadership is stewardship, not command - the measure of a leader is what continues after they step back. This is where the Mantle is worn in the chair.

For the learner. The best captains lead toward their own unnecessary - they build a crew that no longer needs them. You will practice both seats: leading, and being led. Both are the lesson.

The flow. Week 22 opens what leadership actually is (command versus stewardship, “lead toward your own unnecessary”) and introduces rotating command. Week 23 is find-your-style, expedition leadership (plan and lead a real outing together), and the hard parts - the loneliness of the final call, disappointing someone, being disagreed with, honoring the quiet leaders. Week 24 harvests a real act of leading peers *and* of being led well.

Two kinds of leading are built here, and the second is the one the Council needs. **Rotating command** teaches you to sit in the chair and decide. **Rotating facilitation** teaches you to hold the room from beside it - to hold a question without answering it, so the group can. Each learner takes the convener's chair for a low-stakes *real* cohort disagreement and practices refusing to decide. Debrief warmly (“here's the moment you reached for the answer when your job was to hold the question”).

Use well-known captains as public teaching examples of different styles - “which do you lead like?” Present them as public figures anyone can study, never as insider lore.

Things to say. - “Leadership is stewardship, not command. The measure of a leader is what keeps going when they step back.” - “Lead toward your own unnecessary. A crew that no longer needs you is the goal, not a loss.” - “Leading quietly from the back is a different kind of leadership, not a weaker one.” - (The loneliness of command) “When the hard call comes, you make it alone. The crew can advise; the crew can't decide. And here's the thing no one warns you about, and its answer: the captain with a life to go home to - the vineyard, the crew you love - makes better hard calls than the one who only has the chair.”

The settle and the closing minute. Carry the settle and glad close. Closing minute as usual.

Watch-fors. Guard against the room rewarding the loudest; name and honor the quiet leaders. Being led is a skill too - a learner who only ever leads has not finished the lesson, so rotate

genuinely. Hold the hard parts internally, not for optics. In a mixed-age room, do not let the graduating captains' weight set a ceiling the younger learners measure against - every turn in the chair is honored equally. Collaborative and safe by design; no second adult needed. This is a fitting home for a ready learner to hold a real disagreement with ordinary support.

What you'll need. Real group tasks and a real outing to lead; a low-stakes real disagreement for the facilitation practice; the settle in place.

Session 7 - The Council (weeks 25-30, long) - the harvest, one of the three heaviest

What it's for. To make a hard call in the open, before your people - reasoning from principle, naming the cost, honoring dissent, and either finding the third option or, when there isn't one, choosing anyway with your eyes open. This is the mountain the whole year climbed toward, named on day one. The learner wears the Mantle to hold the room.

For the learner. A council is not a debate to win. It is people of good faith reasoning together toward the best hard call - naming the cost, honoring the dissent, and, when the choice is a false either-or, refusing it to find the third way; and when the either-or is real, choosing from principle and carrying the cost. The exhibition is your reasoning, not a verdict to be judged.

The flow. Weeks 25-26 build the deliberative form and work both kinds of dilemma - the one with a real third option (find it: that is skill) and the genuinely no-win one (every path costs something you cannot get back). Weeks 27-28 build and rehearse the deliberation in the tribe's safety. Week 29 is final rehearsal and setting the room. Week 30 is the public Council and the feast.

The Council is built as a real form, or teenagers in front of an audience default to what school rehearsed - debate to win:

- **Named, rotating roles:** a *convener* (holds the question, not a position), *voices* (argue the live positions in good faith), a *scribe* (writes the reasoning where the room can see it), and a *steward of the absent* (whose only job is "who is affected by this who is not in the room?").
- **A six-phase sequence:** Frame, then Divergence (surface every position and the fear under it, before anyone argues), then the mandatory Steelman, then the Cost Ledger (every path's cost and who pays, on the board), then the Turn (is the either-or real or inherited? - the Third Chair), then the Sense of the Room (where the reasoning arrived, and where it honestly did not).

- **The Steelman, mandatory and physical:** you may not argue your own position until you have voiced the best version of the one you reject, well enough that its holder says “yes, that’s it.” This builds honoring dissent into the bones. Forum Theatre from Session 4 pays off here.
- **The Third Chair:** an empty chair placed between hardened sides, with four questions - what is each side protecting? Is the “or” real or inherited? What would honor both values at once? And, when there is no third option, choose from principle and carry the grief honestly.
- **A scribe and a board:** reasoning written where all can see becomes the object in the room, not the performers. The strongest unresolved dissent is read into the record in the dissenter’s own words and left standing, unrefuted, as part of the harvest. A good decision carries its dissent forward visibly.
- **Consecrate and release:** a marked opening (“this is not ordinary talk”) and a closing that completes the council without resolving the dilemma (“we did not solve it; we reasoned honestly, together, in front of our people; the council is closed”). That release lets a young person carry an unresolved hard thing without it becoming an open wound.

Let the Council deliberate something with real consequence to the community - a real policy, a real trade-off - so the reasoning matters because it is used, not graded.

Things to say. - “A council isn’t a debate. A debate has a winner. A council has discernment.” - “You can’t argue your side until you’ve said the other side’s best case so well its holder would say, yes, that’s it.” - “Sometimes there’s a third door. Sometimes there isn’t. Half the wisdom is finding it; the other half is knowing when there isn’t one and choosing anyway, with your eyes open.” - (The pass signal) “If you need the floor back, just [the agreed word or gesture]. No cost, no explanation.” - (The release) “We did not solve it. We reasoned honestly, together, in front of our people. The council is closed.”

The settle and the closing minute. Open settle, mid-work discharge, close return; pre-brief before the Council. Build a Council that cannot be failed, somatically: a pass signal (a word or gesture that returns the floor at zero cost - freeze is an autonomic state, not a choice, so make it safe); ground-before-you-speak taught as the captain’s own craft (feet on the floor, one breath, regulation as competence not remediation); the audience briefed as witness, not judge (a room of warm faces is co-regulation at scale); and the feast protected as the come-down, not one more thing to get right (eating together in company is the body’s signal that the danger is over).

This is where the closing minute reaches its whole-arc culmination. The public Council is an opening onto the social plane and needs its private re-crossing afterward. The capacity to close your own openings, for life, is the deepest thing this year hands a graduate.

Watch-fors. Second adult required on the deep days of the real deliberation and the public Council - public moral deliberation is exposure on exposure. The dilemma is always external, never a learner's own life; no forced self-disclosure. A learner may pass, pause, or come back at zero cost.

What you'll need. A real community dilemma with actual stakes (at least one with a possible third option, at least one genuinely no-win); the roles and the six-phase form; a scribe's board; the Third Chair; a second adult for the deep days; the pass signal and exit ramp confirmed; the feast planned as the come-down; the referral pathway live.

Part 4 - Closing the year and the Launch

The Council harvest

The public Council is the year's harvest and the arc's. It is the exhibition of reasoning, never a verdict. Close it with the release that completes it without resolving the dilemma, and protect the feast as the come-down. After the public opening, everyone takes the private re-crossing - the closing minute at the arc's scale.

Before moving on - or, for a graduating captain, before the Launch - hold two closes. First, a **co-authoring close**: the learner reviews the year's design *with* the guide ("here is how The Helm was built, and why; tell me what to change"). Then, when the time comes, the **Captain's Log ownership handoff** ("it is yours; take it; no copy kept").

The season-scale re-crossing

Seat the season-scale closing on the last fallow day of the year, named plainly, symmetrical to how the year opened. It is not a new ceremony - the fallow day already exists; give it its one true sentence:

SAY

"Before what comes next: your closing minute at the season's scale - what did you meet this season, what do you carry, what's different in you now."

For a learner staying on for another season, this is their arc-scale close between seasons. For the founding cohort, it flows into the Launch.

The Launch rite

For the founding cohort - the first ever to complete the full cycle - the Launch is a true rite of passage, built with the three movements every real threshold-crossing has. It is not a graduation that happens *to* you; it is a threshold you *cross through*. The guide opens the rite, never the system.

Separation - the un-belonging. The part everyone skips because it hurts, and skipping it is why so many graduations feel hollow. Look back and read the Growth Record together - arrive at where you have been. Then the grief-and-gratitude beat, held as the real *work* of this phase: the ending named directly - “this was your home; you are being released from it” - allowed to be sad, held, unrushed, with a real exit available. Do not borrow the de-roling mechanic for this grief. De-roling steps you out of a role that was never you; leaving home is stepping out of a self that absolutely *was* you. Never teach a young person to de-role their own real sorrow. A learner leaving an unstable home for an uncertain future is not only excited; hold it as coach-not-therapist care.

Liminality - the threshold, held. The between-space: no longer a learner, not yet launched. The Star Chart - the map of where they have been - is given here as a threshold-object, not a graduation slide, at the exact moment they must navigate by it alone, with a silence around it that no one fills. Then they craft the next-step document - their plan for themselves, learner-authored and guide-witnessed, not the studio’s plan for them.

Reincorporation - the crossing, witnessed, with a change of standing. The actual step into adulthood, seen by their people. The handoff comes first: generate the Growth Record Portrait export, choose its visibility, take it - this beat cannot be ceremony over a placeholder, so the real, learner-held export must exist before any real learner walks this rite. Then the Captain’s Log is handed over (“it is yours; take it; no copy kept”). Then the learner decides what to do with the Mantle - keep it (this is who I am now) or leave it (it belonged to this place) - either choice true, the choosing being the rite. Then leaving a gift for the room. Then the witnessed crossing over a literal threshold - a doorway, a line stepped over - into a circle of adults who receive them as an adult and address them differently on the far side. A rite that does not change your standing in your community’s eyes is a going-away party; this one changes it.

The empty exit. Then the Launch itself: the door closes and stays unlocked from the learner’s side. No come-back nudge, ever. No re-engagement campaign, no alumni pull, no upsell at the threshold. A launched learner who never returns is a success, not a loss. This is not negotiable under any future pressure.

Leaving a gift for the room

The rite is built around what the learner *takes*, but a threshold is also a community losing a member. So the launched learner leaves one small, sovereign thing behind for the room - a word to the next captain, a mark, their Vineyard-thing. The cohort marks the departure *as a cohort*, not the guide performing it at them - the threshold felt from both sides of the door. For the founding cohort, what they leave becomes the room's first inheritance, turning a series of departures into a lineage.

The learner with no people is most exposed here. "Crossing witnessed by your people" is the day the young person with no family falls hardest. Name the tribe as *your people*, in advance and explicitly - the same inclusion floor the whole program holds, applied to the most tender day of nine years.

What the learner walks out holding: the Growth Record (the backward face - their trail), the next-step document (the forward face - their plan), and the Captain's Log (their private voice, always theirs, never read for assessment). And the practice they carry inside them - the settle, and the three fixed lines they can run on themselves at a kitchen table at 2 a.m. for the rest of their life.

The arc completes.

"We evoke - we never extract." The honesty is the gift; the container is the care. Held, this year transforms.